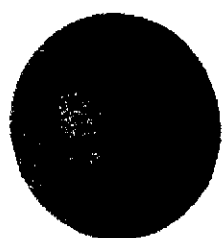


The games were tight in the NCAA Men's Tournament on Saturday and OSU wasn't the only team that had to go to OT to get a win. **Page B4**



DAN COUGHLIN

Violence has always been part of sports

I was staring at a blank screen while stirring several ideas around in my head. "You were doing that 90 minutes ago," said videotape editor Ray Justavick. "Because all the ideas are so good, I can't pick just one," I said.

"Everyone seems to be wearing green," said Ray. "In honor of the Irish, write about fights."

Good idea because earlier this week Irish rugby player Trevor Brennan was banned from the game for life for punching a fan, which seems like a harsh penalty in a game that inherently involves good-natured shoving, kicking, biting and punching.

There's something hypocritical about the disciplinary panel of the European Rugby Union.

I can understand why Brennan was short-tempered. The circumstances alone will drive you crazy. It was back on Jan. 21 that Brennan, an Irishman, was playing for a French team against a Northern Ireland team in the Heineken Cup in London.

Brennan, 33, said he retaliated against a group of Northern Ireland fans who had insulted his mother and poured beer on him.

So into the stands he went and punched a fan named Patrick Bamford. Somewhere out there Mike Curtis is applauding. (Google him. Baltimore Colts linebacker.)

A lifetime suspension is difficult to rationalize when measured against Ty Cobb's 1912 attack on a fan in New York. The fan, a certain Otto Blotz, had been heckling Cobb for two days when Cobb cracked. He went into the stands and rattled his off Otto's face like hitting fungoes in pregame practice. It soon was discovered that Mr. Blotz had only one hand and on that hand he had only two fingers, making it difficult to defend himself. Cobb was suspended for one week.

Maybe the National Hockey League overreacted against New York Islanders forward Chris Simon by suspending him for 25 games for smacking an opponent from the hated Rangers in the face with his stick.

Blood was once an important byproduct of the National Hockey League. It was built on violence. You know the old gag, "I went to the boxing matches and a hockey game broke out." In this incident, however, Simon went too far.

It was March 8 that Ryan Hollweg of the Rangers checked Simon particularly hard. Simon was left dazed and out of sorts. Moments later he retaliated by taking his stick with both hands and applying it forcefully against Hollweg's face. A few stitches in the chin fixed up Hollweg and he's fine.

The NHL declared that Simon's actions were unacceptable and that he has "forfeited the privilege of playing." Even Simon acknowledged, "There is absolutely no place in hockey for what I did."

You think the league office didn't browbeat him?

See COUGHLIN, B3

NCAA: OHIO STATE 78, XAVIER 71

OSU avoids X-tinction

NEXT UP

WHO: OSU vs. winner of today's Tennessee-Virginia game
WHEN: Thursday, time TBA
WHERE: Alamodome, San Antonio, Texas
TV/RADIO: Channel 19; WEOL 930-AM, WKNR 850-AM
TODAY ON CH. 19

• Virginia vs. Tennessee, 12:10 p.m.
• Florida vs. Purdue, 2:15 p.m.
• Kansas vs. Kentucky, 5 p.m.

Lewis' 3-pointer caps amazing comeback; Buckeyes roll in OT

Shaun Bennett
The Chronicle-Telegram

LEXINGTON, Ky. — Ohio State senior Ron Lewis wasn't going to let anything spoil his big day.

The senior shooting guard calmly spun off a screen to the right side of the 3-point arc and drained a long 3-pointer to tie the game with two seconds left in regulation, and the top-seeded Buckeyes went on to a 78-71 overtime victory over No. 9 Xavier to advance to the Sweet 16 in San Antonio.

But Saturday's huge comeback win — the Buckeyes were down nine with less than three minutes to go — wasn't the "big day" Lewis was referring to. That game only had a year of his time invested in it. He was talking about four years' worth of effort.

"I'm graduating (today)," Lewis said. "Now I'm going to be able to enjoy it."

Lewis will earn his sociology degree today, and he'll be able to wear a little bit bigger smile as he walks onto the stage.

Big only begins to describe both the shot Lewis made to cap a furious Ohio State rally and the 27-point, eight-rebound performance he turned in during the South regional second-round game at Rupp Arena.

"I was just trying to get an open look," Lewis said of the tying shot. "I told Mike (Conley Jr.) before we left the huddle to get me the ball. He found me and I got the open look."

Conley, the Buckeyes' freshman point guard, took a cue from the upperclassman, hitting a 3-pointer and a pair of layups to spark a 10-0 run in overtime — freshman reserve Daequan Cook hit a 3-pointer to finish

See OSU, B5



OSU guard Ron Lewis celebrates as the Buckeyes put Xavier away in overtime on Saturday in Lexington, Ky. Lewis hit the biggest shot of his career — a game-tying 3-pointer to force OT — to save OSU's season.

AP

THE TOURNAMENT TRAIL: REGIONAL FINALS

Double dose of heartache

Foul trouble proves fatal as Falls falls

Steve Byrne
The Chronicle-Telegram

TOLEDO — Tyler Sparks was just getting warmed up. Olmsted Falls' star senior scored seven straight points in a minute's time to help his team cut an eight-point deficit to two with 2:22 to play.

Five seconds after sinking a 3-point basket, Sparks fouled Upper Sandusky's Alex Falk. It was his fifth foul.

Sparks had plenty of company on the bench. Teammates Dave Pellerite, Pat Pellerite and Kyle Bungard had already fouled out. Alex Sedlay would join them later.

That was the way it went for Olmsted Falls on Saturday in its 91-81 loss in the championship game of the Toledo regional.

"I'll say this right now," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said, "Upper Sandusky is a great team. They deserve all the success they've had. You can't play that kind of team with your subs, and that's what we were forced to do."

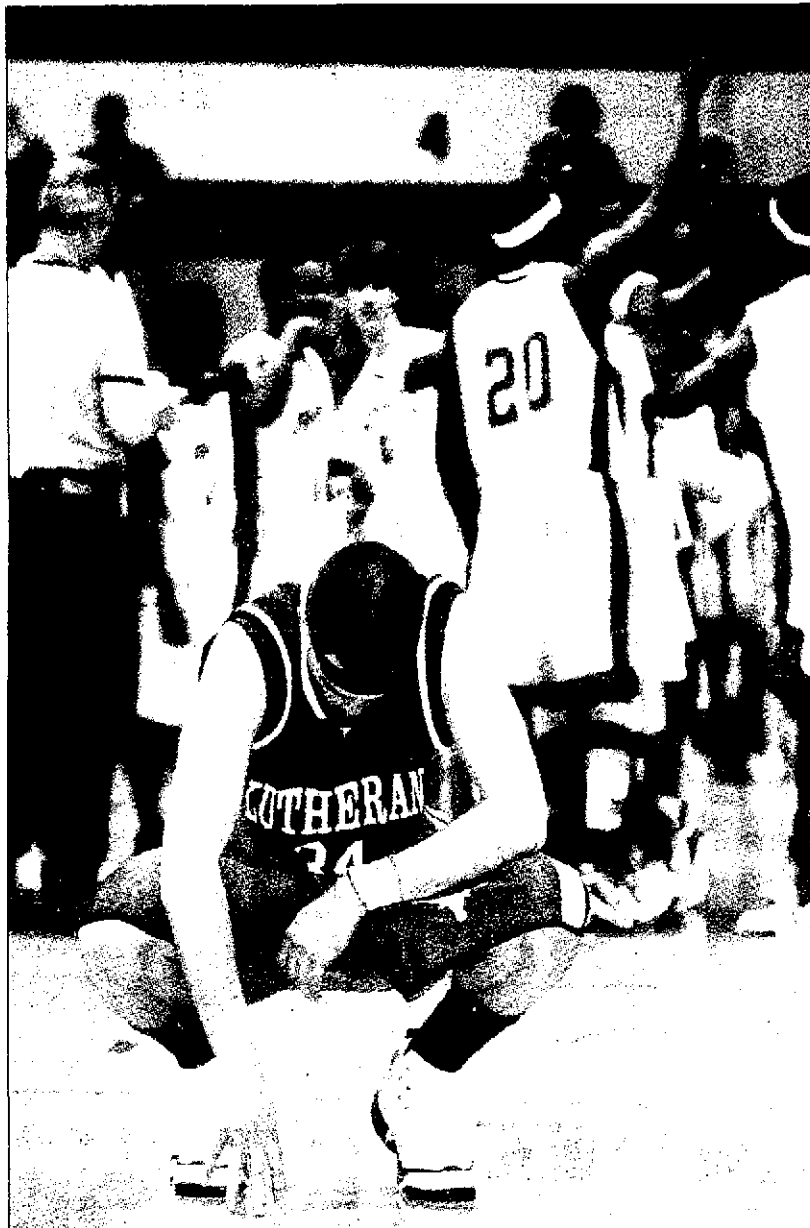
Olmsted Falls (22-3) committed 34 fouls, 25 in the second half. Upper Sandusky (22-3) went to the free throw line 25 times, 15 in the fourth period, for 47 shots. The Rams hit 33 of them and were 17-of-28 in the final period.

"When you're out there with five subs it's tough to beat anybody, especially a team of that caliber," Donahue added. "I've never had more than one guy foul out in 18 years of coaching. We had one guy foul out of a game this year."

"Apparently, we played slow basketball. That was my fault. I didn't have them ready to play fast basketball."

Both teams played fast basketball. The teams combined for 129 field-goal attempts.

See FALLS, B2



JASON MILLER / CHRONICLE

VASJ players celebrate in the background as Lutheran West's Mike Telzrow feels the pain of Saturday's regional final loss in Canton.

CAVALIERS 82, JAZZ 73

Cavs' 'D' a thing of beauty

Rick Noland
The Chronicle-Telegram

CLEVELAND — It was as ugly as expected, but for vastly different reasons.

A sellout crowd of 20,562 finally got its chance to boo Carlos Boozer on Saturday night at Quicken Loans Arena, but the fans' anger didn't begin to compare to the ugliness of the game, which ended with the Cavaliers defeating the Utah Jazz, 82-73.

It was so ugly, in fact, that Cleveland's eighth straight win ended up being beautiful.

"It was two great defensive teams," Cavaliers power forward Drew Gooden said. "You're going to have a nasty offensive game, but our defense got it done for us."

That it did, as the red-hot Cavaliers (41-25) overcame 37.5 percent shooting from the field (33-of-88), 17.6 percent shooting from 3-point territory (3-of-17) and 50 percent shooting from the line (13-of-26) to win going away.

They did it with excellent defense and by outrebounding Utah 61-42, including a whopping 37-18 margin in the second half.

"It was a huge night for us on the glass," Cleveland coach Mike Brown said. "That had a lot to do with us pulling this one out."

The whole Boozer saga ended up fading into the background.

See CAVS, B7



'Horns come up just short

Tim Gebhardt
The Chronicle-Telegram

CANTON — Villa Angela-St. Joseph's student section had special T-shirts emblazoned with a "We're Still Here" logo for Saturday's regional final at the Canton Fieldhouse.

They may want to change that to "Barely" following the Houdini-like escape the Vikings performed Saturday in getting past Lutheran West 55-52 to advance to their second straight

Division III Final Four

The Longhorns' satisfying season came to a bitter end against VASJ, last year's runners-up at the Value City Arena. Lutheran West finished with a sparkling 22-2 mark, a record coach Phil Argento was extremely proud of in spite of the final loss.

"We graduated seven seniors," Argento said of his past two years of unbeaten regular seasons. "I'll take 22-2. Everybody in our league

See 'HORNS, B2

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